Week 16: Parables

How to Read the Bible — 19-Week Study

Jesus taught constantly in parables — tonight we'll look at what they were actually built to do.

1. Think of a time someone made a point to you through a story instead of just telling you directly — a parent, a friend, a movie. Why do you think they told a story instead of just saying it plainly? Did it land differently?

2. **Read Luke 10:25-37.** In the story itself, who passes by the wounded man without stopping, and who actually helps him (vv. 31-33)? Most people summarize this as a story about being a good person who helps those in need. But look closely at who's asking Jesus the question, and why (v. 25, 29). What is Jesus actually confronting by making a despised Samaritan the hero and the respected religious leaders the ones who fail?

3. Jesus' parables often refuse to hand listeners a tidy moral — instead they leave the audience to draw their own conclusion, the way Nathan's story about a stolen lamb forced King David to convict himself before he realized the story was about him. Why might indirect, unfinished stories change people more effectively than direct instructions or lectures?

4. **Read Matthew 18:25-35.** What does the master do for the first servant (v. 27), and what does that same servant then do to a fellow servant who owes him money (vv. 28-30)? Where do you see this same pattern show up in your own life or relationships — having received grace, but being slow to extend it to someone else?

5. Many of Jesus' parables feature an authority figure (a king, master, father, or landowner) alongside two very different responses from those under him. Why do you think Jesus kept returning to this setup — one authority, two contrasting responses — when he talked about God's kingdom?

6. **Read Luke 15.** What does each owner do the moment the lost thing is found — the shepherd with his sheep, the woman with her coin, the father with his son (vv. 5-6, 9, 20-24)? Jesus tells these three connected stories all as a direct response to

religious leaders grumbling that he was welcoming "sinners" to his table (Luke 15:1-2). Which of the three images (a wandering sheep, a lost coin, a runaway son) feels closest to your own story of being sought out or welcomed back? Why?

7. In the parable of the two sons, the father runs to embrace the younger son before he can finish his rehearsed apology, and then goes out a second time to plead with the resentful older brother standing outside the party. What does this suggest about how God pursues both the obviously lost and the quietly resentful?

8. Jesus deliberately taught in a way that revealed truth to those willing to wrestle with it while leaving it puzzling to those who weren't. Why might God prefer that kind of teaching over simply stating things as clearly and directly as possible?

9. Of the three passages we read tonight, which parable feels like it's aimed most directly at you this season — the story of the Samaritan, the unforgiving servant, or the lost sheep, coin, and son? What's one thing you sense it's inviting you to reconsider or change?